

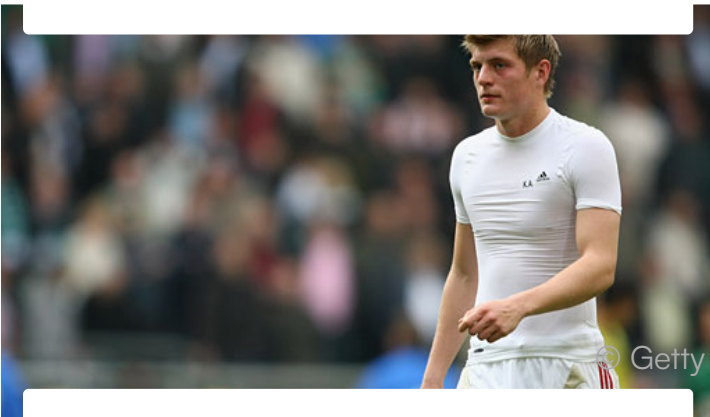
Bundesliga

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The puzzle Toni Kroos

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He was always the best of his age, was hunted by all top clubs and ennobled by Oliver Kahn and Mehmet Scholl. In the meantime, however, Toni Kroos' career has stalled. Now Leverkusen is fighting



DISPLAY

Champions League evenings are always very special in the youth center of FC Bayern. The record champions' greatest young talents can then always sit in front of the television a little longer than usual and dream for almost two hours of making it into the premier class themselves.

Every now and then Werner Kern joins this group. Bavaria's youth boss smiles when his protégés loudly scold a play by Cristiano Ronaldo or cheer a splendid solo by Lionel Messi.

"Let the Toni Kroos do it"

However, when it comes to FC Bayern, Kern says, there is usually peace in the room and everyone listens very carefully. Kern still remembers an evening from a few years ago. "The reporter told something about a lack of creativity in the Bayern midfield. Then the boys said: 'Mr. Kern, in a year or two, let's

Almost three years have passed since that evening. The deficits in the Bayern midfield are already or still exist, and Toni Kroos is no longer wearing the record champions' jersey.

The 19-year-old has been loaned to Bayer Leverkusen for almost a year, and not only the talents of that time in Kroos made up the future Bayern playmaker.

Swarm the barge and plaice

Oliver Kahn raved about the best "what I've seen in the youth field for years". Mehmet Scholl was impressed by Kroos' game intelligence, Ottmar Hitzfeld made him the youngest Bavarian player in Bundesliga history at the age of 17 and 265 days, and manager Uli Hoeneß immediately reserved the jersey with the prestigious number ten.

of another club. But why? Is Kroos too bad, too lazy or is he not satisfied with enough? Do the Munich residents have no sense of talent, or is a club like FC Bayern simply not the right platform to gain a foothold in professional football?

Hoeneß brakes the hype

However, Kroos takes the first steps to become a professional with Bayern. But from the beginning you want to take it slowly on Säbener Straße. Manager Hoeneß brakes all public hype, coach Hitzfeld only uses the youngster sporadically. Under no circumstances should he be burned.

In his first Bundesliga season, Kroos made twelve appearances and was three times in the starting eleven. Bastian Schweinsteiger was allowed to run eight times from the start in his first season for Bavaria a few years earlier.

Kroos feels no trust

Kroos is not happy about the limited playing time, but in summer 2008 Jürgen Klinsmann came to the record champion as a new coach. Everything should get better under him. Also for Kroos. At the start of the season against HSV, the then 18-year-old was on the pitch for 90 minutes. After that, however, he is only used five times in the league, four of them as a substitute.

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performances, then feel the trust that I need. And then the constancy comes automatically," said Kroos the other day. He never felt this trust in Bavaria.

Numerous offers at the age of 13

But the accusation quickly becomes loud that Kroos does not have enough bite, does not want to torture himself sufficiently for his big career and relies too much on his talent.

After all, that had always made him the best of his age. "Since he was in a selection game for the first time, the phone has been ringing with us all the time," says father Roland. At the age of 13, Kroos had offers from numerous clubs in Germany and abroad.

"Defensive bitch" and "naive"

His father ensures that he continues to work on himself. "He is particularly critical. He never made it easy for me and my brother, asked for a lot and made it clear to us from the start that we had to do more. That's why we did a lot more," says Kroos.

So the midfielder is not too comfortable. But then what? The "Kölner-Stadt-Anzeiger" once described him as a "defensive bitch" because of his deficits in the backward movement, as "sometimes ingenious, but far too often a little

Heynckes dampens euphoria

And so Kroos was sent from Munich to Leverkusen "in the apprenticeship" (Franz Beckenbauer) to "get a finished player back", as Hoeneß emphasized in early 2009. So far, however, Kroos has had a hard time at Bayer, although it came to ten league games in the last second half of the season despite injury, but rarely set accents.

Only now does Kroos begin to convince. The way you have wanted it for a long time - at FC Bayern, in Leverkusen and probably across the entire football republic. He was last allowed to run three times from the start, scored twice and delivered strong performances.

And Kroos is celebrated again. "Now the boy has made two reasonably good games and everyone will be nervous right away," says Jupp Heynckes. The Bayer coach steps on the euphoria brake because he knows that Kroos can quickly turn out to be very different, especially when Renato Augusto is fit.

Wooden houses: "We would buy it"

Nevertheless, Heynckes found a learning process with his protégé. "I told Toni a few weeks ago what he had to do better. He is an excellent soccer player, but it also includes other things like physique or changing

And last but not least, Kroos would also like to be kept in Leverkusen beyond the summer. "We would buy it from the Munich residents or at least borrow it for a year longer," says Bayer Managing Director Wolfgang Holzhäuser.

"Kroos is our player"

Hoeneß, however, makes it clear: "We are happy to talk to Bayer about everything, but certainly not about a change from Toni Kroos. **Toni Kroos is our player.** He has a contract from 1 July 2010, "said Hoeneß of the "picture ".

Heynckes also wants to keep Kroos in Leverkusen longer: "Bavaria and Kroos would be well advised if he stayed another year. Here he gets game practice, can develop further. " With Bavaria, it is becoming increasingly difficult as a young player because you have to deliver top performances all the time: "But if Bavaria wants him back, there is no way around it."

Kroos himself does not want to comment on his future. Bayer or Bavaria? It is another question in Toni Kroos's riddle.

Everything about Toni Kroos